The links in the chain of causation between the challenged Government conduct and the asserted injury are far too weak for the chain as a whole to sustain respondents' standing. In *Simon* v. *Eastern Kentucky Welfare Rights Org.*, *supra*, the Court held that standing to challenge a Government grant of a tax exemption to hospitals could not be founded on the asserted connection between the grant of tax-exempt status and the hospitals' policy concerning the provision of medical services to indigents.[24] The causal connection depended on the decisions hospitals would make in response to withdrawal of tax-exempt status, and those decisions were sufficiently uncertain to break the chain of causation between the plaintiffs' injury and the challenged Government action. *Id.*, at 40–46. See also *Warth* v. *Seldin*, *supra*. The chain of causation is even weaker in this case. It involves numerous third parties (officials of racially discriminatory schools receiving tax exemptions and the parents of children attending such schools) who may not even exist in respondents' communities and whose independent decisions may not collectively have a significant effect on the ability of public school students to receive a desegregated education.

The idea of separation of powers that underlies standing doctrine explains why our cases preclude the conclusion that respondents' alleged injury "fairly can be traced to the challenged action" of the IRS. *Simon* v. *Eastern Kentucky Welfare Rights Org.*, *supra*, at 41. That conclusion would pave the way generally for suits challenging, not specifically identifiable Government violations of law, but the particular programs agencies establish to carry out their legal obligations. Such suits, even when premised on allegations of

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[24] *Simon* v. *Eastern Kentucky Welfare Rights Org.*, *supra*, framed its standing discussion in terms of the redressability of the alleged injury. The relief requested by the plaintiffs, however, was simply the cessation of the allegedly illegal conduct. In those circumstances, as the opinion for the Court in *Simon* itself illustrates, see *id.*, at 40–46, the "redressability" analysis is identical to the "fairly traceable" analysis. See n. 19, *supra*.

several instances of violations of law, are rarely if ever appropriate for federal-court adjudication.

> "Carried to its logical end, [respondents'] approach would have the federal courts as virtually continuing monitors of the wisdom and soundness of Executive action; such a role is appropriate for the Congress acting through its committees and the 'power of the purse'; it is not the role of the judiciary, absent actual present or immediately threatened injury resulting from unlawful governmental action." *Laird* v. *Tatum*, 408 U. S., at 15.

See also *Gilligan* v. *Morgan*, 413 U. S. 1, 14 (1973) (BLACKMUN, J., concurring).

The same concern for the proper role of the federal courts is reflected in cases like *O'Shea* v. *Littleton*, 414 U. S. 488 (1974), *Rizzo* v. *Goode*, 423 U. S. 362 (1976), and *Los Angeles* v. *Lyons*, 461 U. S. 95 (1983). In all three cases plaintiffs sought injunctive relief directed at certain systemwide law enforcement practices.[25] The Court held in each case that, absent an allegation of a specific threat of being subject to the challenged practices, plaintiffs had no standing to ask for an injunction. Animating this Court's holdings was the principle that "[a] federal court . . . is not the proper forum to press" general complaints about the way in which government goes about its business. *Id.*, at 112.

Case-or-controversy considerations, the Court observed in *O'Shea* v. *Littleton*, *supra*, at 499, "obviously shade into those determining whether the complaint states a sound basis for equitable relief." The latter set of considerations should therefore inform our judgment about whether respondents

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[25] In *O'Shea* v. *Littleton* and *Rizzo* v. *Goode*, the plaintiffs sought wide-ranging reform of local law enforcement systems. In *Los Angeles* v. *Lyons*, by contrast, the plaintiff sought cessation of a particular police practice. The Court concluded in *Lyons*, however, that this difference did not distinguish the cases for standing purposes as long as the plaintiff could show no realistic threat of being subject to the challenged practice.

have standing. Most relevant to this case is the principle articulated in *Rizzo* v. *Goode*, *supra*, at 378–379:

> "When a plaintiff seeks to enjoin the activity of a government agency, even within a unitary court system, his case must contend with 'the well-established rule that the Government has traditionally been granted the widest latitude in the "dispatch of its own internal affairs," *Cafeteria Workers* v. *McElroy*, 367 U. S. 886, 896 (1961),' quoted in *Sampson* v. *Murray*, 415 U. S. 61, 83 (1974)."

When transported into the Art. III context, that principle, grounded as it is in the idea of separation of powers, counsels against recognizing standing in a case brought, not to enforce specific legal obligations whose violation works a direct harm, but to seek a restructuring of the apparatus established by the Executive Branch to fulfill its legal duties. The Constitution, after all, assigns to the Executive Branch, and not to the Judicial Branch, the duty to "take Care that the Laws be faithfully executed." U. S. Const., Art. II, § 3. We could not recognize respondents' standing in this case without running afoul of that structural principle.[26]

C

The Court of Appeals relied for its contrary conclusion on *Gilmore* v. *City of Montgomery*, 417 U. S. 556 (1974), on *Norwood* v. *Harrison*, 413 U. S. 455 (1973), and on *Coit* v. *Green*, 404 U. S. 997 (1971), summarily aff'g *Green* v. *Con-*

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[26] We disagree with JUSTICE STEVENS' suggestions that separation of powers principles merely underlie standing requirements, have no role to play in giving meaning to those requirements, and should be considered only under a distinct justiciability analysis. *Post*, at 789–792. Moreover, our analysis of this case does not rest on the more general proposition that no consequence of the allocation of administrative enforcement resources is judicially cognizable. *Post*, at 792–793. Rather, we rely on separation of powers principles to interpret the "fairly traceable" component of the standing requirement.

nally, 330 F. Supp. 1150 (DC). Respondents in this Court, though stressing a different injury from the one emphasized by the Court of Appeals, see *supra*, at 752–753, place principal reliance on those cases as well. None of the cases, however, requires that we find standing in this lawsuit.

In *Gilmore* v. *City of Montgomery*, *supra*, the plaintiffs asserted a constitutional right, recognized in an outstanding injunction, to use the city's public parks on a nondiscriminatory basis. They alleged that the city was violating that equal protection right by permitting racially discriminatory private schools and other groups to use the public parks. The Court recognized plaintiffs' standing to challenge this city policy insofar as the policy permitted the exclusive use of the parks by racially discriminatory private schools: the plaintiffs had alleged direct cognizable injury to their right to nondiscriminatory access to the public parks. *Id.*, at 570–571, n. 10.[27]

Standing in *Gilmore* thus rested on an allegation of direct deprivation of a right to equal use of the parks. Like the plaintiff in *Heckler* v. *Mathews*—indeed, like the plaintiffs having standing in virtually any equal protection case—the plaintiffs in *Gilmore* alleged that they were personally being denied equal treatment. 465 U. S., at 740–741, n. 9. The *Gilmore* Court did not rest its finding of standing on an abstract denigration injury, and no problem of attenuated causation attended the plaintiffs' claim of injury.[28]

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[27] On the merits, the Court found that permitting such exclusive use by school groups was unlawful, because it violated the city's constitutional obligation, spelled out in an outstanding school-desegregation order, to take no action that would impede the integration of the public schools. Exclusive availabililty of the public parks "significantly enhanced the attractiveness of segregated private schools . . . by enabling them to offer complete athletic programs." 417 U. S., at 569.

[28] Indeed, the Court stressed the importance of a particularized factual record when it stated that it was "not prepared, at this juncture and on this record, to assume the standing of these plaintiffs to claim relief against certain nonexclusive uses by private school groups." *Id.*, at 570, n. 10. "Without a properly developed record," said the Court, it was not clear